

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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The Land

The land was very important to ancient Israel because agriculture was the main way people made a living. Most Israelites were farmers or herders, and their survival depended on the land's ability to produce crops and support livestock.

God gave the Israelites the privilege and responsibility of living in Canaan. This was part of God's covenant with Israel (1 Kings 8:33–40; see also Deuteronomy 28). The land was central to Israel's relationship with God, who promised it to Abraham and his descendants (Genesis 12:1–3; 13:14–17). The nation of Israel lived as those who tended and owned the land. The land was Israel's "inheritance" (Deuteronomy 4:21). God gave it to them and required their loyalty (Deuteronomy 4:40). God expected the people to manage the land well and serve him faithfully.

Sadly, God's people chose their own way to live. They worshiped pagan gods and themselves (2 Kings 17:7–17). So, God allowed foreign nations to gradually take Israel's land (for example, 2 Kings 8:20–22; 13:1–3; 17:3). Eventually, Assyria invaded the northern kingdom, sending the Israelites into exile (17:5–6, 22–23).

Through these events, God warned Judah, the southern kingdom, that they would lose their land if they did not change (2 Kings 21:8). Unfortunately, they did not listen (21:9). Their unfaithfulness led to them being forced out of the land by the Babylonians (25:1–21).

Israel's rebellion and failure to manage the land God gave them is a warning to us. God has redeemed us through Christ Jesus so we can live faithful and productive lives (John 15:16; Ephesians 2:4–10). If we are unfaithful and unproductive, we might lose our role in serving Christ (John 15:1–2, 6). By remaining connected to him, we "bear much fruit" and grow in our faith (John 15:5).

God's people always have a tendency to sin (see Romans 3:23; 1 John 1:8, 10). But God is always ready to forgive and restore those who repent and to renew the blessings of his covenant (see 1 John 1:9). Jesus, who mediates the new covenant between God and his people, is also their advocate in heaven (Matthew 26:27–28; 1 John 2:1). In the end, those who remain faithful to God will receive the blessings of the new heaven and the new earth (1 Peter 1:3–5; Revelation 21:1–7).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:1–3; 13:14–17; Leviticus 26:1–46; Deuteronomy 28:1–68; 1 Kings 8:29–51; 9:3–9; 2 Kings 17:18–23; Psalms 24:1; 89:11; 1 Peter 1:4; Revelation 21:1–7

The Last Things and the Thessalonians

The Christians in Thessalonica eagerly accepted the apostle Paul's teachings about the day of the Lord and Jesus' second coming. Yet, this led to questions and guesses about the end of time.

They wondered what would happen to Christians who died before Jesus returned (1 Thessalonians 4:13–18). They also asked when "the Day of the Lord" would come (5:1–11). They wondered if Christians would experience God's wrath (1:10; 5:9). Paul reassures the church by explaining these topics and reminding them of the teachings they had already received (4:13–5:11).

Paul probably expected Jesus to return during his lifetime (4:15). Yet, he also knew the final event would occur unexpectedly, "like a thief in the night" (5:2). The way to be ready for the end is not by knowing the date but by living with Christian alertness. This means keeping a constant spiritual watchfulness and being ready to meet Jesus.

The Thessalonians needed to understand the deaths of fellow Christians. Paul does not discuss the state of Christians between their death and Jesus' return. Instead, he focuses on the resurrection. Just as God raised Jesus from the dead, Christians who die will also be raised when he returns. They will rise from the dead first, then join the living Christians to meet Jesus at his royal coming.

Paul tried to explain the Christian hope. But the Thessalonian Christians became confused by false teachings that said, "the Day of the Lord has already come" (see 2 Thessalonians 2:2). To correct this misunderstanding, Paul discussed this topic further in his second letter to the young church (see 2 Thessalonians 2:1–12).

Passages for Further Study

Mark 13:1–37; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–5:11; 2 Thessalonians 2:1–12

The Law and the Spirit

A common question many Christians ask is whether Christians need to follow Old Testament laws to spiritually grow in their faith. Does obeying God's law help Christians become more holy?

When the Christians in Galatia heard and accepted the good news about salvation through faith in Christ, they also received the Holy Spirit. This Holy Spirit

served as proof that they were true believers. God not only gave his Spirit to them but also performed miracles among them (Galatians 3:5). The Christians in Galatia knew from their own experience that the Holy Spirit has the power to transform them into new people. The apostle Paul had taught them to depend on the Spirit for guidance in their lives.

After Paul left Galatia, Jewish-Christian teachers came to the area. These teachers taught something different. They said people needed to follow God's law both to be accepted by God and to become holy and mature. These teachers claimed that Paul's teaching about becoming more holy by the Holy Spirit (instead of carefully obeying God's law) would lead people to break God's laws and commit sins.

Paul answered these teachers by saying God does two important things through faith:

1. God counts or considers us righteous because of our faith.
2. God actually makes us righteous through faith by the work of the Holy Spirit (Galatians 5:16–26). Paul explained that people who depend on the Spirit and follow the Spirit's guidance will not sin. This is because God's Spirit will never lead people to do wrong things.

The real problem is not that people do not understand what is right and wrong. Our conscience, which God gave us, tells us when we are doing something wrong. God's law makes his standards for right living even clearer (Romans 7:7–12). The real problem is that our hearts are often stubborn and sinful. We also lack the wisdom to know the right thing to do in different situations. Because of sin's effects on human nature, we struggle to apply God's word in a way that matches what God truly wants.

The law cannot improve our condition. But when the Holy Spirit guides and controls us, he transforms our desires so that we do things that please God (Galatians 5:22–23; Romans 8:5–14). God's Spirit helps his people fulfill the true meaning and purpose of his law. But following the law should not be our main goal or focus. The law is just our "guardian" (Galatians 3:24–25). Instead, we should focus on trusting God, relying on the Spirit, and loving others. God's Spirit gives us the desire and strength to do these things in a way that pleases God.

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 11:16–17, 24–30; Jeremiah 31:33–34; Ezekiel 36:26–27; Luke 24:49; Acts 5:32; Romans 7:1–8:17; 12:2; 2

Corinthians 3:7–18; Galatians 3:2–5; 5:5, 16–26; Hebrews 12:14–29

Laziness and Hard Work

God created Adam and Eve and placed them in the garden of Eden to care for it, not just to relax and enjoy it (Genesis 2:15). Work is not a punishment from when humans first sinned. Instead, God made work to be a good and valuable part of his creation from the beginning.

The book of Proverbs often condemns laziness (being unwilling to work or make an effort when you should). Proverbs compares lazy people to a door that moves back and forth but never goes anywhere (Proverbs 26:14). It also teaches that lazy people are foolish (22:13). Their lack of work leads to poverty and death (6:6–10; 10:26; 15:19; 18:9; 19:15, 24; 20:4; 21:25; 22:13; 24:30–34; 26:13–16). In contrast, hardworking people are wise. Their work leads to having enough money and a good life (10:4–6; 12:11; 13:4; 20:13; 31:10–27).

Ultimate meaning and fulfillment do not come from hard work (Ecclesiastes 2:17–26). We should not forget God's ability to provide (Psalm 127:2). But, we have no excuse to be lazy. God designed us to use our gifts and abilities to be productive and provide for ourselves and others (Ephesians 4:28; 1 Thessalonians 4:11–12; 2 Thessalonians 3:6–13).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 23:12; Proverbs 6:6–11; 10:4–6, 26; 12:11, 24, 27; 13:4, 11; 14:4, 23; 15:19; 18:9; 19:15; 21:5, 25; 24:30–34; 26:13–16; 28:19; 31:10–31; Ecclesiastes 2:18–26; 4:5–6; 5:12; 9:10; 11:4–6; Romans 12:11; Ephesians 4:28; 1 Thessalonians 4:11–12; 2 Thessalonians 3:10–15

Legalism

The law was very important to the Jewish people. Their understanding of religion often focused on following rules and ceremonies. This was natural to them because God had given his law to the Jewish people. He did this to show he had chosen them as his people. God also gave them the law as a way for them to confirm and keep the covenant agreement he had made with them.

Yet, many Jews added to God's laws, creating rules for almost every situation. They often did this to avoid breaking any of God's laws. As Jesus often pointed out, these extra rules sometimes made it hard to follow God's instructions (Mark 7:1–15). In addition, many Jews believed that simply following the law would make them favored by God.

The apostle Paul often encountered issues with strict legalism in the early churches. For example, in Colossae, false teachers influenced by Jewish beliefs insisted that Christians follow certain rules to express their faith (Colossians 2:16–23). Paul criticized this, emphasizing faith in Christ. Christ is the fulfillment of all God’s plans and purposes and is the center of true devotion.

This does not mean that rules for behavior are bad in themselves. Some rules, like the prohibition on lying, plainly show an aspect of Christ’s character (Colossians 3:9). Paul also did not mind if individual Christians set rules for themselves that they believe will help them better obey Christ (compare Romans 14:5; 1 Corinthians 8). Yet, they must not force others to follow these self-imposed rules.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 23:13–33; Mark 7:1–15; Galatians 2:14–21; Colossians 2:16–23

Letters to the Seven Churches

In the letters to the seven churches of Asia, the apostle John uses a single literary pattern (Revelation 2–3). Each letter starts with an address to the “angel of the church” in a specific city. It then mentions an aspect of Jesus’ appearance from the vision of “the Son of Man” (1:12–18).

Jesus says that he knows each church and describes its condition. He gives advice or judgment and promises a reward for obedience. Each time, Jesus emphasizes the importance of paying full attention to the Holy Spirit’s message to the churches.

Interpreters often divide the seven letters into separate messages, symbolizing seven types of people or time periods. Yet, these letters were first from Jesus to specific local churches in Asia. Jesus knows each local gathering of Christians and encourages them to follow him faithfully.

Together, these letters form a unified message for the church at all times and places, knowing its weaknesses. Any local gathering of Christians might resemble one of these churches, and each community has people similar to those Christians. Jesus invites every community of Christians to examine itself using all these messages.

Passages for Further Study

Revelation 2:1–3:22

Life After Death

Writers in the Old Testament describe the place where dead people are as beneath the earth’s surface (Ezekiel 26:20). Sometimes, the earth swallows them alive (Numbers 16:31–33; Psalm 55:15). But usually, “the cords of death” take them down “and swallows them” (Psalm 18:4–5; Numbers 16:30; Job 24:19; Psalm 49:14; Isaiah 5:14; 14:11). In the Old Testament, the afterlife is often considered a gloomy, hopeless place of no return (Job 7:9; Isaiah 38:18).

In the book of Job, the main images of the place of the dead include:

- Sheol, which is described as dark and dusty (Job 11:8; 14:13; 17:13, 16; 24:19; 26:6);
- a pit filled with decay (Hebrew *shakhat*; see 9:31; 17:14; 33:18, 22, 24, 28, 30); and
- the grave (Hebrew *qeber*; see 3:22; 5:26; 10:19; 17:1; 21:32).

The Old Testament sometimes suggests rescue from the grave (see 1 Samuel 2:6; Psalms 16:10–11; 30:3; 49:15; 56:13; 73:24–26; 86:13; 139:7–10; Isaiah 26:19). Job hopes Sheol might ease his troubles (Job 3:13–22; 14:13–17). He hopes a redeemer might defend him after death (19:25–26). Yet, only the New Testament fully promises redemption from death (1 Corinthians 15:50–58).

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 2:6; 28:11–15; 1 Kings 17:20–22; 2 Kings 4:32–35; Job 3:13–22; 7:9; 14:13–17; 17:13–16; 19:25–27; Psalms 6:5; 16:10–11; 17:15; 49:15; 86:13; 88:11; 139:8; 141:7; Proverbs 1:12; 15:11; Isaiah 26:19; 38:18; Ezekiel 26:20; Matthew 22:31–32; Romans 8:23; 1 Corinthians 15:50–58; Philippians 3:21

The Limitations of Law

The law was central to God’s special agreement (the covenant) with the people of Israel. Many Jews in the apostle Paul’s time, including Jewish Christians, still considered it as essential for living. Therefore, Paul often addresses questions about the law, especially in his letters to the Romans and the Galatians. He explores this deeply in Romans 7. There he argues that the law of Moses, instead of improving people’s lives, caused sin and brought death (see 7:5).

Paul wants his readers to understand that the law is not to blame. God’s law is good and holy (Romans 7:12). But it cannot change the human heart or will. Whether Paul describes a non-Christian, a mature Christian, or an immature Christian, the message is the same. The law cannot defeat human sin (see Romans 7:14–25).

God gives the law to people who, because of their link to Adam's curse, are already easily controlled by sin's power. We may want to obey God's commands, but we find it impossible. Only a new and powerful experience of God's power and grace in Jesus Christ can rescue us (Romans 7:25). Through God's Spirit, Jesus set us free "from the law of sin and death" (Romans 8:2).

If God's good and holy law cannot save us, human laws are even less helpful for spiritual health. Whether these laws come from a religious leader, a tradition, or a church, they cannot change the human soul. They can instruct us, but they cannot give us the strength to follow them. God's law offers a guide for the new life given by grace. But it cannot replace the power of God's grace, which comes through Christ's work.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 5:1-33; 6:17-25; Joshua 24:19-27; Ezra 7:25-26; Psalms 1:1-3; 19:7-14; 78:56-59; 119:144; Isaiah 24:5; 26:4-8; Jeremiah 31:33-34; Hosea 4:6; 8:12; Habakkuk 1:4; Matthew 5:17-20; 7:12; Mark 7:8-9; Luke 16:16-17; John 1:16-17; 7:19; Acts 13:38-39; Romans 2:13-29; 3:19-21, 27-28; 4:13-16; 7:1-25; 8:3-4, 7; 9:4, 31-32; 10:3-5; Galatians 2:16-21; 3:2, 10-13, 17-25; 5:1-4; 1 Timothy 1:5-11; Hebrews 8:7-13; 10:1-18; 1 John 3:4-6

Little Faith

The Greek term translated as "little faith" and related terms appear five times in the Gospel of Matthew (Matthew 6:30; 8:26; 14:31; 16:8; 17:20). It also appears once in Luke (Luke 12:28; compare James 1:6-7). This term refers to a specific event, not a permanent failure.

In Matthew, "little faith" occurs when Jesus' disciples lack knowledge or act without faith in a certain situation (Matthew 16:8-11). If someone always lacks faith, it is called "unbelief" (see 13:58).

Some examples of "little faith" include:

- when the disciples do not understand their worth or God's protection (6:30);
- when the disciples do not trust God's protection during danger (8:26; 14:31);
- when the disciples misunderstand Jesus' teaching about yeast (16:8); and
- when the disciples fail to cast out a demon (17:20).

These are failures in specific situations, not a total lack of faith.

The term faith includes two ideas: trust (personal reliance on the Lord) and belief (acceptance of truths). Matthew's concern with "little faith" is about a follower of Jesus lacking trust in a specific situation,

rather than failing to believe in Jesus as Lord and Savior. Jesus wants his followers to not only believe in him but also to trust, love, and obey him (see Matthew 7:21-29; 22:34-40).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 6:30; 7:21-29; 8:26; 13:58; 14:31; 16:8; 17:20; 22:34-40; Luke 12:28; James 1:6-8

The Little Horn

In the vision of the prophet Daniel, the little horn represents a king. It has human-like features, such as eyes and a mouth. This imagery is typical of apocalyptic literature.

"Apocalyptic" is from a Greek word meaning "reveal." So, this kind of message or writing reveals the hidden plans of God. Apocalyptic writings often using mysterious language and images. The little horn draws Daniel's attention because of its boastful speech and violent actions against other kings, God's people, and the Most High God.

What or who is the little horn? The little horn in Daniel 7:8 links to evil figures in 9:27 and 11:40-45. Antiochus IV Epiphanes shares qualities with the little horn in 7:8, but they are not the same (8:9-14, 23-25; 11:21-39).

Both ancient and modern interpreters believe the little horn represents the future antichrist (a powerful leader who will strongly oppose God and God's people). Some think certain historical figures from the Greek and Roman empires, like Antiochus IV Epiphanes, Nero, Caligula, and Domitian, have partially fulfilled this vision. According to this perspective, this future person will be a man, not a demon or Satan.

Some see the little horn as a symbol of evil opposing God and his people. Some interpreters think no single person will fulfill this vision. Instead, they believe it represents evil forces in the world. Others believe the antichrist has already appeared. The New Testament suggests the idea of the antichrist will have a final fulfillment (see 2 Thessalonians 2:3-12; 1 John 2:18; 4:3; 2 John 1:7; Revelation 13:1, 5; 16:13-14; 17:11; 19:20-21; 20:10).

This little horn reminds God's people that evil strongly opposes God and his people. The king mentioned here takes over the world's kingdoms (Daniel 7:8). But his evil system will not win because God will destroy evil. God's people can find comfort in knowing this time of evil will not last long (Revelation 12:12). God will destroy the works of this evil kingdom (Daniel 7:11-12).

God's chosen ruler, who appears "like a son of man" (looking like a human being), is given authority by God (called "the Ancient of Days" in this vision; Daniel 7:13-14). He will rule with God's approval and power, and his rule will last in a kingdom that cannot be destroyed. God encourages his people to endure and remain faithful. They live in hope of a righteous kingdom where God will live among them (see Revelation 21:3). "The zeal of the LORD of Hosts will accomplish this" (Isaiah 9:7).

Passages for Further Study

Daniel 7:8, 11, 20-21, 24-26; 8:9-12; 9:26-27; Mark 13:14; 2 Thessalonians 2:5-12; 2 John 1:7; Revelation 13:1-10; 20:10

Living for Christ

The apostle Paul writes from prison, "For to me, to live is Christ" (1:21). Why should Christians commit their lives to Jesus Christ?

1. Christians recognize that they owe everything to Christ. This includes their salvation. They show their gratitude by committing their lives to his service (see Romans 12:1).
2. Christians accept Christ as their master and Lord. They obey Christ's guidance in their lives. They understand that they belong to the Lord and do not live only for themselves (see Romans 14:7-9; 2 Corinthians 5:14-15).
3. Christians now share in Christ's death and resurrection. They have "died with Christ" and are "alive to God in Christ Jesus" (see Romans 6:3-14; compare Galatians 2:19-20). They have a new identity in Christ (Romans 8:14-17; Ephesians 1:11, 14; Philippians 3:20).
4. Christians understand that all valuable things are in Christ. Worldly things that once seemed important have lost their appeal. Nothing compares to the immense value of knowing Christ (Philippians 3:7-11; Ephesians 1:3-3:21; Colossians 1:15-3:4).

Passages for Further Study

Romans 6:3-14; 8:14-17; 12:1; 14:7-9; 1 Corinthians 6:19; 2 Corinthians 5:14-15; Galatians 2:19-20; Ephesians 1:11, 14; Philippians 1:21; 3:7-11, 20

Living Water

Israel was a land often experiencing drought. People were very aware of water sources and quality. There were few year-round springs and rivers. So, people relied on a deep hole built underground to collect and store winter rain. These are called cisterns. They used wells to access underground water.

In Jewish culture, "dead water" meant standing or stored water. "Living water" meant moving water, like rivers, springs, and rainfall. This water was valuable because it was fresh. Since it came directly from God, people used it for ceremonial washings (see Leviticus 14:5-6, 50-51; 15:13; Numbers 19:17-19).

The difference between "dead" and "living" water explains the confusion of the woman of Samaria when Jesus offered her "living water" (John 4:12). Samaria does not have a permanent river. If Jacob had to dig a well there, how could Jesus offer better water?

Jesus spoke about living water again in Jerusalem during the autumn Feast of Tabernacles (John 7:37-39). This feast, held in a dry season, focused on water. In this context, Jesus stepped forward and made a bold claim. Anyone seeking living water should come to him and drink. Jesus is the source of living water. He came directly from God and brought divine renewal through the Holy Spirit.

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 14:5-6, 50-51; 15:13; Numbers 19:17-19; Song of Solomon 4:15; Jeremiah 2:13; 17:13; John 4:10-14; 7:38-39; James 3:11-12

The Lord of Nations

Both the Old Testament and the New Testament state that the Lord is the one true God. God is supreme over all nations and peoples at all times. Even if rulers do not believe in or acknowledge him, God remains in control. Kings and emperors might think they control everything in their lands, but they are mistaken. The Lord God is ultimately in charge.

The Old Testament prophets said that the Lord God of Israel chose the kings or emperors of each nation. God held rulers accountable for the morality of their policies and how they practiced them. This idea is clear in Jeremiah 18, 25, and 46-51.

Nations that did not acknowledge the one true God would encounter severe judgment. For some nations, God promised that a small group (called a remnant) would survive (see Jeremiah 46-51).

The Lord wants people from every nation to turn to him and follow him with sincere hearts and complete dedication. He has always wanted all people to live righteous lives and experience the joy of truly worshipping him. The book of Revelation describes people from every nation, tribe, and language worshipping God in the future (Revelation 7:9-10).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 8:20–22; 9:29; 2 Kings 19:22–37; Jeremiah 18:5–11; 25:15–29; 46:1–51:64; Daniel 2:19–21; 4:34–37; Haggai 2:7; Matthew 28:18–20; Acts 12:21–23; Romans 13:1–7

Love in the Community of Christ

Living in a community is not always easy. The community of Jesus Christ (the church) has often experienced disunity and division throughout its history. Even in its earliest days, the church struggled with unity issues (see 1 Corinthians 1:11–17; Galatians 2:11–16).

To solve conflicts in the Christian community, Christians must show love to one another. Jesus taught this (Matthew 22:37–40; John 13:34–35; see Leviticus 19:18). The apostle Paul emphasized it (Romans 13:8–10; 1 Corinthians 13:1–13). It appears throughout the New Testament (1 Peter 1:22; 1 John 2:7–11; 3:10; 4:7). Loving others in the Christian community is key to Christian values (Romans 12:9–10; 1 Thessalonians 4:9; 2 Peter 1:5–8).

This kind of love is not just a feeling but a promise to help others, shown through actions. Followers of Christ should treat each other in such a way that their faith communities are famous for acts of love. The author of Hebrews gives examples of showing love in real ways within Christian communities (Hebrews 13:1–6).

These include:

1. Being welcoming
2. Helping those persecuted or imprisoned
3. Remaining faithful in marriage
4. Not letting money control their lives

Many people misunderstand love and the character of the church. So, the church must obey the Lord's command to "continue in brotherly love" (Hebrews 13:1).

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 19:18; Matthew 22:39; John 13:34; Romans 12:10; Romans 13:8; 1 Corinthians 13:1–13; 1 Thessalonians 4:9; Hebrews 6:10; Hebrews 10:24; Hebrews 13:1–6; 1 Peter 1:22; 2 Peter 1:7; 1 John 2:10; 1 John 3:10; 1 John 4:7

Loving Others

Jesus said that loving your neighbor is the second most important commandment in the Old Testament (Mark 12:31). The command to love sums up the entire Old Testament law (Matthew 22:40; compare 7:12; 9:9–13; 12:1–13; see Romans 13:8–10). Jesus criticized the Pharisees for not showing love (Matthew 9:13; 12:7; 23:4, 13–14, 23). Love identifies a true follower of Jesus (John 13:34–35). It indicates a real experience of God (1 John 2:9–11; 3:11–18; 4:7–21).

For the apostle Paul, love is more important than any spiritual gift and is the most important virtue. Love "is the bond of perfect unity" (Colossians 3:14). Without love, Christian ministry has no value (1 Corinthians 13:1–3). Paul summarized Christian ethics as "faith expressing itself through love" (Galatians 5:6).

Love naturally comes from Christian faith. It is the primary fruit of the Holy Spirit (Galatians 5:22). It is the most important motivation for Christian ministry. As Christians spiritually grow, they will desire to love others as Christ did.

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 19:18; Hosea 6:6; Matthew 7:12; 9:9–13; 12:1–13; 22:37–40; 23:2–4, 13, 23; John 13:34–35; Romans 13:8–10; 1 Corinthians 13:1–13; Galatians 5:6, 22–23; Colossians 3:12–14; 1 John 2:7–11; 3:11–18; 4:7–21